Clothing Problems of the Hermit Crab

Unlike 'normal' crabs, hermit crabs have no shells to protect their soft bodies. But they make up for this by finding and wearing the discarded shells of other animals, mainly molluscs and snails. Sometimes, two hermit crabs decide that they want the same shell, and this leads to an exciting tug of war. The right size may be difficult to find, and one can then see naked and worried hermit crabs scuttling about, inspecting one shell after another. This is the time when hermit crabs must worry about being eaten, because they are a favourite food for many fish.

The hermit crab is different
And doesn't really jell
With all the other normal crabs,
Because it has no shell.

This unfair omission
Is certainly not right …
Heard of legless centipedes?
Or zebras without white?

But the hermit's attitude
Is positive and fine …
Finders keepers, he believes,
And what I find is mine.

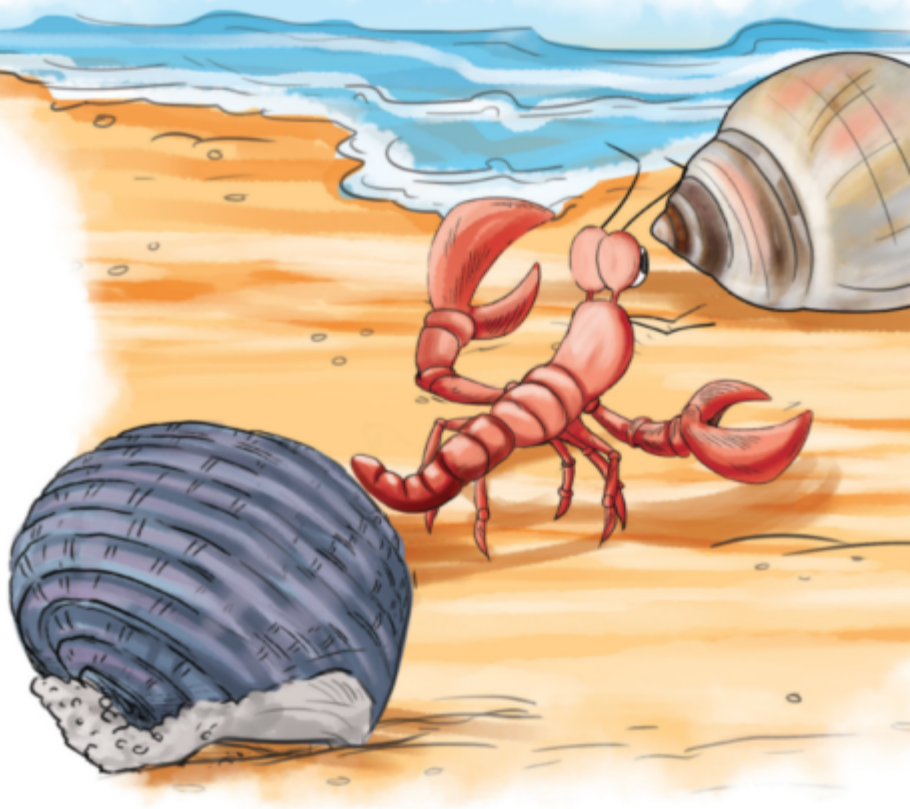
So the naked hermit crab
Finds a shell and tries it …
This he has to keep on doing,
To find the perfect fit.

discarded: thrown away molluscs: creatures with soft bodies and hard outer shells, like snails and slugs
tug of war: a hard struggle between two opposing players/teams scuttling: running with quick, short steps
jell: work well together omission: the act of leaving out or excluding something or someone finders keepers: anyone who finds something has a right to keep it

He scuttles away proud as pie
Quite a dapper sight …
But soon he's grown a little more,
His shell is now too tight.

Time to look for clothes again
And he's about to bawl …
But here's a gown just made for him,
Collar size and all.

His favourites are the periwinkles
As he likes the colour scheme …
Pink and grey, a touch of brown,
A little dash of cream.



Zai Whitaker

Zai Whitaker is a naturalist, conservationist and author who grew up in Mumbai, India. She has written over twenty books such as *Kali and the Rat Snake*, *Cobra in My Kitchen* and *Sálim Mamoo and Me*. This poem has been taken from her collection of poems called *Boastful Centipede and Other Creatures*.

Make connections

In this section, we will:
- identify and interpret the central ideas of a poem.
- recognize relevant details to answer questions based on the poem.

(C-2.1, C-2.2)

Answer the following questions based on the poem.

1. Tick (✔) the correct option.

a. The poem is mainly about
   i. a hermit crab. ◯
   ii. all other crabs. ◯

b. The poem says that
   i. most crabs have shells. ◯
   ii. most centipedes do not have legs. ◯

c. A pair of rhyming words from the poem is
   i. really—jell. ◯
   ii. scheme—cream. ◯

d. The poem is _____ in tone.
   i. serious. ◯
   ii. humorous. ◯

e. The line in the poem which shows comparison through a simile is
   i. *He scuttles away as proud as pie.* ◯
   ii. *Finders keepers, he believes.* ◯

dapper: dressed in a fashionable and neat way bawl: cry loudly periwinkles: creatures that live in water and have shells

2. Read the lines and answer the questions that follow.

   a. *But the hermit's attitude*
   Is positive and fine …
   Finders keepers, he believes,
   And what I find is mine.

      i. How was the hermit crab different from all other crabs?

      ii. Which two words in the stanza describe his attitude?

      iii. What did the hermit crab find? Why did he keep what he found?

   b. *His favourites are the periwinkles*
   As he likes the colour scheme …
   Pink and grey, a touch of brown,
   A little dash of cream.

      i. Whose favourites were the periwinkles?

      ii. What did the creature have to do over and over again? Why?

      iii. Which of these is a periwinkle shell preferred by the hermit crab? Tick (✓) the correct one.

3. The poet compares the process of finding a shell to trying on clothes. Pick out such lines from the poem and write how the comparison is brought about.

4. What qualities of the hermit crab does the poet describe? Which ones do you share or admire?

Appreciation

Personification

In this section, we will:
- learn to identify and use personification.
- write a poem using personification.
(C-2.1, C-2.2, C-3.3)

- Time to look for clothes again
  And he's about to bawl

- His favourites are the periwinkles
  As he likes the colour scheme

In these lines, the poet gives human qualities to the hermit crab. She describes the crab finding a shell as if it were a person trying on different clothes to find one that fits best. The poet indicates that much like human beings, the crab is also capable of feeling emotional distress during challenging times. Moreover, the crab is described as having likes and dislikes, just like human beings do. This is called personification.

Personification is a literary device in which objects or animals are given human qualities or characteristics.

1. Read these lines from the poem 'The Crocodile' by Lewis Carroll and answer the questions that follow.

How doth the little crocodile
Improve his shinning tail,
And pour the waters of the Nile
On every golden scale!

How cheerfully he seems to grin,
How neatly spreads his claws,
And welcomes little fishes in,
With gently smiling jaws!

a. Circle the examples of personification in the poem above.

b. If the crocodile was a real person, what kind of person do you think it would be?

2. For each verse given below, decide which element is being personified: the rain, the wind or the sun.

a. I saw you toss the kites on high
And blow the birds about the sky;
And all around I heard you pass,
Like ladies' skirts across the grass
O _____, a-blowing all day long…

b. Great is the _____, and wide he goes
Through empty heaven without repose;
And in the blue and glowing days
More thick than rain he showers his rays.

c. Let the _____ kiss you
Let the _____ beat upon your
head with silver liquid drops …

3. Use the picture given below as a prompt to write a poem with examples of personification. Remember, lines of a poem don't always have to rhyme.